

Ryanair and Spain clash over airport charges

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【要点】

- ・スペイン政府とライアンエアが地域空港の料金をめぐって対立しており、ライアンエアは複数の地域空港から撤退・減便している。
- ・スペイン運輸相は、ライアンエアの撤退は航空機納入遅延による経営問題を隠蔽するための戦略だと主張している。
- ・ライアンエアは地域空港の料金が高すぎるため新型機を配備できないと反論し、スペイン政府は高収益なマドリッド・バルセロナ空港に集中投資していると指摘している。
- ・スペイン国営空港運営会社AENAが全国の空港料金引き上げを提案しており、政府は9月の採択を予定している。

【メール原文】

Navigating the complex world of EU mobility policy and infrastructure. By TOMMASO LECCA with JORDYN DAHL and MARTINA SAPIO SNEAK PEEK — The Spanish go

Navigating the complex world of EU mobility policy and infrastructure.

By TOMMASO LECCA

with JORDYN DAHL and MARTINA SAPIO

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SNEAK PEEK

— The Spanish government and Ryanair are at odds over charges at regional airports and the low-cost carrier's strategy of shifting capacity toward more profitable hubs.

— Greece's powerful shipping lobby is hardening its stance against the EU-backed IMO climate framework, just as Ireland tries to keep member countries united behind it.

— The political battles over the Industrial Accelerator Act will soon kick off as diplomats and lawmakers return to Brussels.

Good morning, and welcome to Morning Mobility.

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DRIVING THE DAY

MADRID VS RYANAIR OVER REGIONAL AIRPORT CHARGES: The Spanish government and Ryanair are trading accusations over the low-cost carrier's capacity cuts at regional airports. The dispute comes

amid a broader fight over a proposal by national airport operator AENA, which is majority-owned by the Spanish state, to increase airport charges in the entire country. The government is expected to adopt the proposal in September.

Fleeing destinations: Ryanair has spent months criticizing charges at Spain's regional airports, withdrawing from Asturias, Valladolid, Jerez, Tenerife North and Vigo while cutting capacity at several others. The Irish airline has accused Madrid of pocketing more than €800 million in dividends from AENA rather than using the money to reduce charges at smaller airports.

Disguising problems: Spanish Transport Minister Óscar Puente said Sunday that Ryanair's adiós to regional airports was simply "a business strategy that disguises its problems of lack of aircraft to put pressure on the issue of charges." According to the minister, delayed aircraft deliveries are "a problem most airlines are having, because ... the aviation industry is in trouble right now."

Profitability is king: Speaking to news agency Europa Press, Puente also argued that "Ryanair hasn't reduced a single seat in Spain ... it increased [capacity] by more than 2 million seats," concentrating growth at Madrid-Barajas and Barcelona-El Prat. Those "curiously, are the airports with the highest fees" but are also "very profitable" for Ryanair, he added.

Right to reply: Ryanair disputes Puente's explanation. "Minister Puente's claims regarding Ryanair's aircraft deliveries are false and factually incorrect," spokesperson Jade Kirwan said. "Ryanair has taken full delivery of our 210 [Boeing] MAX-8200 aircraft order, but none of them have been deployed to regional Spanish airports because pricing is too high," Kirwan told Tommaso. Ryanair had frequently complained about Boeing delivery delays, but has struck a more optimistic tone about the U.S. planemaker's recovery since last summer.

Back to the charges: "Minister Puente continues to ignore the stark reality that Spain's regional airports are 70 percent empty, doing untold damage to Spain's regional economies, because AENA has priced them out of the market," Kirwan added.

Market rules: "Spain has the airports (albeit empty) and Ryanair has the aircraft — the pricing just needs fixing," she said, adding that the airline would invest again in regional airports if they were "priced competitively."

The bigger picture: Ryanair's fight with AENA reflects a deeper tension, according to Andrew Lobbenberg, Barclays' head of European transport equity research. Ryanair is targeting the Spanish operator "because the business structure at AENA, with a single national network of airports, is a strategic challenge to the Ryanair business model," Lobbenberg wrote in a research note. The airline "is strongly focused on optimising its airport costs, which fundamentally works by pitting one airport against another," he added. "Where an operator controls a block of airports ... this structure struggles."

MARITIME

GREEK SHIPOWNERS HARDEN IMO BATTLE LINES: Greece's powerful shipping lobby is toughening its stance ahead of next week's IMO climate negotiations, declaring that the proposed Net-Zero Framework "clearly is not the solution" and backing an alternative that would scrap its carbon pricing system and central fund.

Lines drawn: IMO member countries return to negotiations in London from Sept. 1-4, with the Union of Greek Shipowners arguing that talks so far have exposed "significant weaknesses" in the framework. In a statement shared with POLITICO, UGS President Melina Travlos said governments need to give

greater weight to the industry that will ultimately have to implement the measures.

The alternative: UGS instead pointed to the proposal from Panama, Liberia and Argentina as a more “balanced and pragmatic foundation” for negotiations. That plan would replace the IMO framework’s greenhouse gas pricing mechanism and central fund with a more flexible fuel-intensity system linked to the availability and cost of cleaner fuels.

A Brussels headache: The intervention creates a political challenge for the EU, which has until now tried to maintain a common position at the IMO. Greece has one of the world’s largest shipping industries, meaning Athens heads into the talks with a powerful domestic sector openly arguing that the framework the EU has backed needs fundamental changes.

Ireland wants unity: A spokesperson for the Irish Council of the EU presidency told Martina it remains committed to securing “the widest level of support possible” for the final package. The presidency said it “will present the joint EU position on key elements” of the IMO’s mid-term emissions measures, agreed by member countries in July, with further EU coordination meetings taking place this week.

What’s next: UGS insists it remains committed to decarbonization, but its message days before talks resume is clear: the existing framework needs more than tinkering. Whether Greece’s concerns remain an industry position or begin feeding into the EU negotiating line will be one of the things to watch next week.

CHINA’S ARCTIC SILK ROAD TAKES SHAPE: China’s long-discussed Arctic trade route is becoming a commercial reality, after Chinese carrier Sea Legend launched the first regularly scheduled container service to Europe through Russia’s Northern Sea Route.

Why it matters: A new report by the Brussels-based think tank Bruegel argues the breakthrough is not simply that Chinese ships are using the Arctic — they have done so before — but that the route can now be scheduled, priced and repeated, allowing it to become part of regular supply chains between Asia and Europe.

A new route to Europe: Chinese shipping company Sea Legend said in August its service can link China with Northern European ports in around 20 days, roughly half the time of the journey via the Suez Canal. The carrier plans to operate even relatively small container ships on the route during the roughly four-month Arctic navigation season.

Asia piles in: China may not be alone for long. South Korea is preparing a pilot voyage through the Northern Sea Route, while India says it plans to send its first cargo vessel along the corridor in 2027, as Asian shippers look for alternatives to increasingly risky Middle Eastern sea lanes.

CARS

THE BATTLE OVER THE IAA THIS FALL: Summer is over, and that means the political battles over the Industrial Accelerator Act will soon kick off as diplomats and lawmakers return to Brussels. Several automotive files hinge on the IAA, including the proposed corporate fleets regulation and various aspects of the proposed reform for the 2035 emission targets.

Refresher: The IAA is one of the Commission’s flagship industrial policies designed to boost green manufacturing through incentives for greener public procurement, while also defining what qualifies as “Made in Europe.”

U.K. bristling: The IAA will be a major topic of discussion at any future EU-U.K. summit. The proposed corporate fleet regulation sets electrification targets for member states and includes local content requirements for automakers to get supercredits for building small EVs. But the Society of Motor Manufacturers and Traders worries that under the IAA, cars built in the U.K. would not qualify.

Heavyweights: Three EU diplomats tell POLITICO the split in the Council will center on the bloc's two economic giants. Germany is no big fan of the IAA and fears it could impact its export economy, while France wants it to help kickstart its manufacturing sector and has emerged as one of its staunchest defenders.

Exceptions for all: Germany wants the IAA to take a "Made with Europe" approach, as we've previously reported. In Berlin's latest status report seen by our colleague Tom Schmidtgen, Germany wants the ability to apply for exemptions to the IAA's proposed FDI rules.

House drama: Over in the European Parliament, things are equally as contentious, with three committees sharing responsibility for debating the file: Industry, Research and Energy; Internal Market and Consumer Protection; and International Trade.

Party time: Among the groups in Parliament, a more pro-industry coalition is taking shape among the center-right European People's Party — the bloc's biggest group — the centrist Renew Europe, and the center-left Socialists & Democrats, who all want the act to help EU businesses survive. The Greens, on the other hand, fear the IAA risks diluting the EU's climate ambitions and becoming another weapon in the "competitiveness" agenda rather than a green initiative.

Tick tock: The automotive package is also being negotiated this fall with votes in the Council and Parliament expected the first week of November. But implementing any negotiations will be much harder if the IAA is not similarly finalized by year's end.

TESLA DOORS RECALLED IN CHINA: Nearly 3 million Tesla vehicles have been recalled in China, along with another million cars from Chinese brands like Xpeng and Xiaomi over door handles that are difficult to locate. Authorities say the door handles are a safety risk in the event of a crash if the occupants cannot find the handle to open.

Not alone: Chinese authorities announced a ban on the hidden door handles in February. The EU abides by regulations from the United Nations, which is similarly drafting new standards to ensure that electric handles like those in Tesla can be opened even if the car's electricity is cut off.

Headlines

Here's a recap of yesterday's news, along with Pro articles and alerts from overnight.

Europe's debate over how to boost clean manufacturing is about to heat up

The Industrial Accelerator Act wants to solve a wicked problem: promote industry while limiting carbon emissions.

By Ben Makuch · Aug 25, 2026, 06:00 am Europe/Brussels CEST

Trump announces 50 percent tariff increase on Canada for vehicles, steel after trade talks collapse

Trump's comments come after Canadian Prime Minister Mark Carney vowed to retaliate against the U.S. trade stance.

By Jalen Beckford · Aug 24, 2026, 04:27 pm Europe/Brussels CEST

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